







RUINATION (from top left clockwise) A vandalised hall in Naya Mahal palace inside Bhopalgarh fort; dank insides of Khetri House in Jaipur; a caved-in section of the fort ramparts; destroyed furniture in Sukh Mahal; view from the turret at Naya Mahal

termite-eaten furniture, missing chandeliers, animal carcasses rotting on once-splendid carpets, artefacts plundered, steel safes pulled out of thick walls

↘ **Khetri House, Jaipur:** A three-star hotel in the 1980s, closed for business in 1998, strong room robbed in 2004, structure partly burnt down in 2015, "sold off" in forged sales, encroached upon....

in the open market. Three registers that recorded Khetri's moveable assets in 1987, notably, are among the missing pieces.

All this time, displaying a gusto entirely absent on the ground, the state has cussedly refused to let go—despite the case finally turning a corner. In 2016, the Revenue Court Ajmer stayed the last decision in favour of the state: a collector's order on Escheats. Soon, the Rajasthan High Court overturned a 2012 order that had endorsed the state's recourse to Escheats. The state promptly went in appeal—but the climate of opinion in the Supreme Court has been none too favourable either. "We are shocked and amazed at the manner in which the State of Rajasthan has permitted its heritage to be destroyed!" said a three-judge bench on January 18, 2023. The apex court is now supervising restoration. It had already got the main case, on ownership, expedited in the Delhi High Court and that took a similar trajectory—in July 2023, again quashing a 2012 order, the HC upheld the Khetri Trust as the legal heir. A hearing on the state's appeal against it is expected in November. Probate is the primary case—since it would settle ownership if upheld, the Escheats case would become infructuous anyway, especially after the state Revenue Board shut it down in 2023—so the SC has opted to fast-track that hearing. It has not stayed either order, and has signalled that it implies they stand, and that closure is imminent. But the state is not backing off just yet.

Lord Northbrook, a member of the House of Lords who's the lone surviving executor of the will and also a trustee, is befuddled that "the State in India can litigate for 37 years to challenge the succession of its citizens. There is no precedence in the world where the courts will allow this". Not so surprising in India, where the mood after Independence had by default been set against the past excesses of maharajas, and a general mistrust prevailed of private profiteers. In a country despoiled by colonial loot, antique smugglers were national villains and only the State was trusted. The 'nationalisation' of such assets would have been seen as democracy getting its back on royal hauteur. And at stake here was an estate estimated at Rs 2,500 crore.

Khetri, a copper-rich plateau on Rajasthan's northeast fringe, was perhaps the richest among the semi-autonomous *thikanas* around Jaipur. But its palaces hosted episodes that go beyond the usual Rajputana lore. First, there's the not-so-minor Khetri detour of the Nehrus: it's here that the family of Gangadhar Nehru, the last kotwal of Delhi, took refuge during the massacre that followed the 1857 uprising while fixing a new base in Agra. His son, Nandlal Nehru, rose from a teacher to be the diwan of Raja Fateh Singh for a decade. Younger brother Motilal spent some good childhood years here. Some strands of the present succession battle began upon Fateh Singh's death in 1870, when Nandlal had the news concealed till he got nine-year-old Ajit Singh from nearby Alsisar adopted as heir to forestall a British takeover.

An excellent choice, as it turned out. An "intuitive and intelligent sovereign" with interests in the arts, science and philosophy, Ajit's encounter in 1891 with an erudite young monk was to become a chapter in history. Vivekananda was